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Agri-loans Made *Asan*

The installation of ATMs in rural Andhra Pradesh has made the disbursing and accessing of loans easier for the native tobacco farmers

Renuka Rane

Devarapalli, Koyyalagudem and Jangareddygudem are tongue twisters, and one look at the scenery around these villages would make you wonder if they could have any other claim to fame. They are located deep in the interiors of Andhra Pradesh, and are dotted with lush green tobacco fields. The Telugu-speaking inhabitants are, by and large, tobacco cultivators.

The villages act as hub points for tobacco trading. They actually constitute four auction platforms for tobacco under the Northern Light Soil (NLS) category of the agro-climatic zone in

Andhra Pradesh. The entire area has more than 6,000 farmers registered with the Tobacco Board, Ministry of Commerce, Government of India. Hundreds of these tobacco farmers can now claim to be ATM-savvy, courtesy ICICI Bank's Kisan Loan Card scheme. This, then, is their claim to fame...

ICICI's Eye For Progress

While a majority of companies try to appease the all-important global consumer, ICICI Bank modified its loan offering to cater to one specific user group, in this case, the tobacco cultivators of Andhra Pradesh.

In September 2004, ICICI Bank launched the 'Kisan Loan Card'

in Devarapalli in association with the Tobacco Board. Along with it, ICICI Bank also inaugurated four India-specific 'Asan' ATMs (manufactured by NCR Corporation) in Devarapalli, Koyyalagudem and Jangareddygudem. A pilot project by the bank, it involves the disbursing of cash and crop loans to farmers who are registered with the Tobacco Board.

Brahmananda Hegde, deputy general manager, ICICI Bank,

Photograph: Jiten Gandhi
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